

The Case for a Pretribulation Rapture

What the Book of Revelation Reveals

1. Revelation 4:1 as a Picture of the Rapture

Revelation 4:1

“After these things I looked and saw a door standing open in heaven. And the voice I had previously heard speaking to me like a trumpet said, ‘Come up here, and I will show you what must happen after these things.’”¹

Why Pretribulationists see this as a picture of the Rapture:

“After these things” (*meta tauta*) signals a major transition in John's vision—from Christ's messages to the seven churches in chapters 2–3 to the prophetic events that follow. The strong case can be made that this marks the conclusion of the Church Age and the beginning of the prophetic events that follow. The voice “like a trumpet” recalls the trumpet language associated with the Rapture:

- **1 Thessalonians 4:16–17** — “the trumpet of God”
- **1 Corinthians 15:52** — “at the last trumpet”

John is suddenly and supernaturally brought into the heavenly scene, providing a striking picture of the Church being caught away to meet Christ.

From this point forward, John views the unfolding prophetic events from a heavenly vantage point while the judgments of the Tribulation unfold on earth. This fits naturally with the Church having been removed before the judgments begin.

Important note: Pretribulationists do not claim this verse explicitly teaches the Rapture. Instead, they view it as a type or foreshadowing—a symbolic picture that harmonizes with other Rapture passages.

Revelation 1:19 provides an important structural connection:

“Therefore write down what you have seen, what is now, and what will take place after these things.”

Chapters 2–3 deal with the Church, while chapter 4 begins John's vision of “what will take place after these things.”

¹ Unless otherwise noted, all Scripture quotations in this paper are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB).

2. The Church's Absence in Revelation 4–19

The word *ekklesia* (“church”) appears repeatedly in Revelation 1–3 as Christ addresses the seven churches. After Revelation 3, however, the word is not used again throughout the detailed prophetic narrative of chapters 4–19.

The significance becomes apparent when we consider what Revelation describes during these chapters.

Beginning in chapter 6, we find:

- God's judgments upon the earth
- the 144,000 from the tribes of Israel (Revelation 7:4–8)
- the two witnesses (Revelation 11)
- Jerusalem
- the rise and authority of the beast
- those who refuse the mark of the beast
- persecution of saints
- the gathering of the nations for Armageddon

Yet the Church, which dominated chapters 2–3, is no longer addressed as the Church.

Instead, Revelation speaks of *saints*, servants of God, the 144,000 from Israel, the two witnesses, and those who come to faith during this period.

This change is significant. The Church has been prominent throughout the opening chapters, but once John is called into heaven in Revelation 4:1, the prophetic narrative turns toward the judgments and events that characterize the Tribulation.

The Church's absence from the earthly prophetic narrative, together with the presence of redeemed people in heaven, fits naturally with the understanding that the Church has already been raptured.

3. The 24 Elders Are Most Likely Redeemed Believers in Heaven

Revelation 4:4

“And around the throne were twenty-four thrones, and on the thrones sat twenty-four elders dressed in white with golden crowns on their heads.”

The twenty-four elders are most likely individual redeemed believers already in heaven. While Revelation does not explicitly identify them, several details strongly support this understanding.

White Robes

White garments are associated throughout Revelation with righteousness, purity, and victory.

See:

- Revelation 3:5
- Revelation 3:18
- Revelation 6:11
- Revelation 7:9
- Revelation 19:8

The white robes worn by the elders are therefore consistent with glorified believers.

Crowns

The elders wear crowns of gold. Crowns are repeatedly associated with the rewards promised to faithful believers:

- 1 Corinthians 3:11–15
- 2 Timothy 4:8
- James 1:12
- 1 Peter 5:4

This fits naturally with the concept of believers having been rewarded at the judgment seat of Christ.

Thrones

The elders sit upon thrones surrounding God's throne.

This corresponds remarkably well with Christ's promise to His Church:

Revelation 3:21

“To the one who is victorious, I will grant the right to sit with Me on My throne, just as I overcame and sat down with My Father on His throne.”

The combination of thrones, crowns, and white robes strongly fits the description of glorified and rewarded believers.

The Number Twenty-Four

The number twenty-four may correspond to the twenty-four priestly divisions established in 1 Chronicles 24, providing a possible picture of a complete priestly order serving before God.

Another possibility is that the twenty-four elders represent the fullness of God's redeemed people, with twelve corresponding to the tribes of Israel and twelve corresponding to the

apostles. Revelation 21:12–14 brings these two groups together in its description of the New Jerusalem, where the twelve tribes of Israel are associated with the gates and the twelve apostles with the foundations.

This interpretation would make the twenty-four elders most likely individual representatives of redeemed humanity—twelve associated with Israel and twelve with the apostles.

The precise identity of the twenty-four elders is not explicitly stated in Revelation, so this conclusion should be presented as the most likely interpretation rather than as an absolute identification.

The Elders Are Already in Heaven

What is unmistakable is that the twenty-four elders are already in heaven, surrounding the throne of God, before the judgments of Revelation 6 begin. They are clothed in white, wear golden crowns, and sit upon thrones—features that are entirely consistent with redeemed and glorified people in the presence of God.

The elders are also distinguished from the angels. Revelation 5:11 states:

“Then I looked and heard the voices of many angels encircling the throne and the living creatures and the elders...”

This distinction supports the understanding that the elders are a separate group from the angels.

While Revelation does not explicitly identify the twenty-four elders, the evidence strongly favors understanding them as individual redeemed believers in heaven. The possibility that twelve correspond to Israel and twelve to the apostles provides a compelling explanation for the number twenty-four. Most importantly for the Pretribulation argument, these redeemed individuals are already in heaven before the judgments of Revelation 6 begin.

This evidence also fits the broader pattern of Revelation: the Church is prominent in chapters 2–3, John is called into the heavenly scene in 4:1, redeemed individuals are already present around God's throne, and the judgments of the Tribulation follow.

4. The Church Is Promised Deliverance from Coming Wrath

The New Testament repeatedly teaches that believers are not appointed to God's coming wrath.

1 Thessalonians 1:10

“and to await His Son from heaven, whom He raised from the dead—Jesus our deliverer from the coming wrath.”

1 Thessalonians 5:9

“For God has not appointed us to suffer wrath, but to obtain salvation through our Lord Jesus Christ.”

The promise becomes even more specific in Revelation 3:10.

Revelation 3:10

“Because you have kept My command to persevere, I will keep you from the hour of testing that is about to come upon the whole world, to test those who dwell on the earth.”

Christ does not merely promise to protect His Church from the effects of a particular judgment. He promises to keep His Church from *the hour of testing*—a worldwide period that will test those who dwell upon the earth.

The Greek expression *tērēsō ek* means “I will keep you from” and is central to the pretribulation understanding that Christ promises to remove His Church from the coming worldwide hour of testing.

The sequence is compelling:

Christ promises to keep His Church from the coming hour of testing.

The Church is subsequently no longer seen in the earthly prophetic narrative.

The judgments of Revelation then unfold upon the earth.

This fits the Pretribulation Rapture remarkably well.

5. Revelation Identifies the Coming Judgments as God's Wrath

The connection between Revelation 3:10 and the judgments that follow becomes especially important in Revelation 6.

At the opening of the sixth seal, the inhabitants of the earth recognize what is happening.

Revelation 6:16–17

“And they said to the mountains and rocks, ‘Fall on us and hide us from the face of the One seated on the throne, and from the wrath of the Lamb. For the great day of Their wrath has come, and who is able to withstand it?’”

Here Revelation explicitly identifies the coming judgment as *the wrath of the Lamb*.

The people on earth themselves recognize that they are experiencing divine wrath.

This provides a direct connection with Paul's teaching that believers have been delivered from coming wrath and have not been appointed to wrath.

The prophetic sequence becomes increasingly clear:

The Church is promised deliverance from the coming hour of testing.

The Church is seen in heaven.

The judgments begin on earth.

The people of earth recognize that the wrath of the Lamb has come.

This is exactly the kind of sequence that the Pretribulation Rapture anticipates.

6. The Tribulation and Daniel's Seventieth Week

The pretribulation position becomes even stronger when Revelation is viewed alongside Daniel's prophecy of the seventy weeks.

Daniel 9:24

“Seventy ‘weeks’ have been decreed for your people and your holy city...”

Daniel's prophecy specifically concerns *Israel and Jerusalem*.

The final seventieth week is associated with events that correspond closely to the Tribulation described in Revelation.

Daniel 9:27 describes the final week and the ruler who confirms a covenant with many for one week, then breaks that covenant in the middle of the week. Revelation likewise describes the rise of the beast, his authority, his persecution, and his opposition to God.

This distinction is important.

The Church dominates Revelation 2–3.

But during Revelation 6–19, the prophetic focus shifts toward:

- Israel
- Jerusalem
- the nations
- the beast
- the False Prophet
- the Jewish remnant
- God's judgments upon the earth

The 144,000 are explicitly identified from the tribes of Israel.

This change in prophetic focus fits naturally with the dispensational understanding that God's program for Israel resumes after the Church has been removed.

The Tribulation therefore corresponds not to God's program for the Church, but to the final prophetic period concerning Israel and Jerusalem described by Daniel.

7. The Structure of Revelation Supports a Pretribulation Timeline

Revelation unfolds in a remarkably orderly progression:

Chapter 1 — Christ revealed to John.

Chapters 2–3 — Christ's messages to the seven churches.

Chapter 4 — John is summoned into heaven and sees the throne of God.

Chapter 5 — The Lamb receives the scroll and heaven prepares for the judgments that follow.

Chapters 6–18 — The Tribulation judgments and events unfold: seals, trumpets, bowls, the rise of the beast, persecution, Israel, Jerusalem, and the nations.

Chapter 19 — Christ returns visibly to earth in glory.

Chapter 20 — The Millennial Kingdom.

Chapters 21–22 — The eternal state and New Jerusalem.

This structure fits naturally with the following sequence:

Church Age → Rapture → Redeemed in heaven → Tribulation on earth → Second Coming → Millennium → Eternal State

Revelation 4:1 therefore occupies a significant transition in the prophetic structure of the book.

8. The Bride Is Prepared Before Christ's Visible Return

One of the strongest indications that the Church is already with Christ before His visible Second Coming is found in Revelation 19.

Revelation 19:7–8

“Let us rejoice and be glad and give Him the glory. For the marriage of the Lamb has come, and His bride has made herself ready. She was given clothing of fine linen, bright and pure.”

The Bride is already prepared when Christ appears in Revelation 19:11.

The New Testament teaches that believers will stand before Christ for evaluation and reward:

- 1 Corinthians 3:11–15
- 2 Corinthians 5:10
- Romans 14:10–12

This provides a logical sequence:

Rapture → believers gathered to Christ → judgment and reward → preparation of the Bride → marriage of the Lamb → Christ's visible return

The Bride does not appear to be making herself ready after Christ's return; she is already prepared when He appears as the conquering King.

The Church is therefore not waiting on earth for Christ's Second Coming. She is pictured as the prepared Bride accompanying Him when He returns.

9. “Those Who Dwell on the Earth”

Another significant feature of Revelation is John's repeated use of the expression “*those who dwell on the earth.*”

The expression occurs repeatedly in the prophetic chapters:

- Revelation 6:10
- Revelation 8:13
- Revelation 11:10
- Revelation 13:8
- Revelation 13:14
- Revelation 17:8

During the Tribulation narrative, the expression “*those who dwell on the earth*” repeatedly describes those aligned with the rebellious world system and opposed to God.

At the same time, John repeatedly sees worship and redeemed people in the heavenly realm.

The contrast is striking:

Heaven — God's throne, the Lamb, the elders, angels, and worship.

Earth — judgment, rebellion, the beast, persecution, and those who dwell on the earth.

This developing contrast fits naturally with the Church having been caught up to Christ before the judgments unfold.

10. The Rapture and the Second Coming Are Distinct Events

A proper understanding of the Pretribulation Rapture requires recognizing the distinction between the Rapture and Christ's visible Second Coming.

At the Rapture:

1 Thessalonians 4:16–17

“For the Lord Himself will descend from heaven with a loud command, with the voice of an archangel, and with the trumpet of God, and the dead in Christ will rise first. After that, we who are alive and remain will be caught up together with them in the clouds to meet the Lord in the air. And so we will always be with the Lord.”

Christ comes *for* His Church.

At the Second Coming:

Revelation 19:11

“Then I saw heaven standing open, and there before me was a white horse. And its rider is called Faithful and True. With righteousness He judges and wages war.”

Christ comes in visible judgment and glory.

Revelation 19:14 further states:

“The armies of heaven, dressed in fine linen, white and pure, follow Him on white horses.”

Christ is therefore not coming alone. The armies of heaven accompany Him as He returns in triumph.

The distinction is clear:

Rapture: believers are caught up to meet Christ in the air.

Second Coming: Christ returns visibly to earth with His heavenly armies.

At the Rapture, Christ gathers His Church to Himself.

At the Second Coming, Christ returns to establish His kingdom and judge the rebellious nations.

This distinction allows Revelation 19 to portray the Bride already prepared and accompanying Christ at His return.

11. Biblical Typology: God Delivers His People Before Judgment

Scripture repeatedly demonstrates God's ability to distinguish His people from those under judgment.

Noah

Before the Flood, God separated Noah and his family from the wicked world and provided a place of safety.

The Flood then came upon the earth in judgment.

Noah illustrates God's ability to preserve His people through catastrophic judgment.

Lot

Lot provides an especially striking picture of God's people being removed before judgment falls.

Jesus said:

Luke 17:28–30

“It was the same in the days of Lot: People were eating and drinking, buying and selling, planting and building. But on the day Lot left Sodom, fire and sulfur rained down from heaven and destroyed them all. It will be just like that on the day the Son of Man is revealed.”

The order is significant:

Lot was removed.

Then judgment fell.

Peter reinforces this principle:

2 Peter 2:9

“if all this is so, then the Lord knows how to rescue the godly from their trials and to hold the unrighteous for punishment on the day of judgment.”

These examples demonstrate a consistent biblical pattern: God knows how to separate and deliver His people before He pours out judgment.

That pattern harmonizes perfectly with Christ's promise to the Church:

“I will keep you from the hour of testing...”

Summary of the Pretribulation Case

Biblical Evidence	Pretribulation Significance
Revelation 4:1 — “Come up here”	A picture of the Rapture
“After these things”	Marks the transition from the Church's ministry in chapters 2–3 to what follows
Trumpet-like voice	Recalls the trumpet associated with the Rapture
Church in Revelation 2–3	Dominant focus before chapter 4
Church absent from Revelation 4–19	Consistent with the Church being in heaven
24 Elders	Most likely individual redeemed believers already in heaven
White robes	Consistent with righteousness and glorification
Crowns	Consistent with believer rewards
Thrones	Consistent with believers' promised participation in Christ's reign
Elders distinguished from angels	Supports their identification as redeemed humanity
Revelation 3:10	Christ promises to keep His Church from the worldwide hour of testing
Revelation 6:16–17	The coming judgment is identified as the wrath of the Lamb
Daniel 9:24–27	The final prophetic week concerns Israel and Jerusalem
Revelation 6–19	Israel, Jerusalem, nations, Antichrist, and judgment dominate the prophetic narrative
Revelation 19:7–8	The Bride is already prepared before Christ's visible return
1 Thessalonians 4:16–17	Christ gathers His Church to Himself in the air
Revelation 19:11–14	Christ returns visibly with the armies of heaven
“Earth dwellers”	Repeated designation during the Tribulation
Noah and Lot	Biblical pattern of God's deliverance before judgment

Conclusion

The case for a Pretribulation Rapture does not rest upon a single verse, but upon the way the prophetic passages of Scripture fit together. Revelation presents a clear progression: Christ addresses His churches in chapters 2–3, the scene shifts to heaven in chapter 4, and the judgments of the Tribulation unfold from chapters 6–19.

Christ's promise to keep His Church from the coming worldwide hour of testing (Revelation 3:10), the presence of redeemed people in heaven before the judgments begin (Revelation 4:4), the identification of those judgments as the wrath of the Lamb (Revelation 6:16–17), Daniel's seventieth week concerning Israel and Jerusalem (Daniel 9:24–27), and the distinction between Christ gathering His Church and His later visible return (1 Thessalonians 4:16–17; Revelation 19:11–14) form a consistent prophetic pattern.

Scripture also demonstrates that God is able to deliver His people before judgment falls, as seen in Noah, Lot, and the principle stated in 2 Peter 2:9.

Taken together, these truths provide a strong biblical basis for concluding that the Rapture of the Church will occur before the judgments of the Tribulation begin.

Maranatha